

Learn Business Central Financial Reporting in 30 Days

Introduction: What Is Business Central Financial Reporting and Why It Matters

Financial reporting in Dynamics 365 Business Central is a built-in, no-code feature that transforms general ledger data into structured financial statements and analyses. The **Financial Reports** feature gives you insights into the financial data shown on your chart of accounts (COA), allowing you to set up financial reports to analyse figures in general ledger (G/L) accounts and compare general ledger entries with budget entries [1](#). For a financial controller, these reports are indispensable because they are tied directly to detailed transactional postings from the general ledger [2](#), support comparative views such as month-to-date, year-to-date, and prior-year comparisons [2](#), and require no coding – finance professionals can build their own reports and make changes exactly when they need to [2](#). The number of financial reports you can create is unlimited and requires no involvement of a developer [1](#). Robust auditing capabilities, including a Change Log, email notifications, and telemetry, allow you to monitor changes to your financial report definitions and control access to financial reports [3](#). In short, this feature puts the controller in direct control of financial insights, from basic balance sheets to advanced KPI dashboards.

Introduction to This Course

"**Learn Business Central Financial Reporting in 30 Days**" is a structured training programme for financial controllers who are new to Dynamics 365 Business Central. Over 30 days, you will progress from fundamentals to expert-level proficiency with the financial reporting feature. The course is divided into three tiers:

- **10 Beginner lessons** (Days 1–10) – core concepts, out-of-the-box capabilities, viewing, printing, and initial customisation.

- **10 Intermediate lessons** (Days 11–20) – building custom reports, working with row and column definitions, dimensions, budgets, and statistical accounts.
- **10 Expert lessons** (Days 21–30) – auditing, change management, performance optimisation, KPI publishing, cash flow forecasting, and a capstone project.

Each lesson is bite-sized (completable in under 10 minutes) and consists of a brief introduction explaining **why** the topic matters to a controller, a concrete hands-on exercise in a Business Central sandbox environment, and a **Learn More** section linking to the approved Microsoft Learn articles. By the end of 30 days, you will be able to generate and tailor financial reports, draw insights for management, validate report accuracy, and leverage the system's advanced capabilities for strategic financial decisions.

Beginner Lessons (Days 1–10) – Getting Started with Core Reporting

Day 1: Orientation – Financial Reports in Business Central and Their Value

Introduction: As a controller, you need fast, trustworthy financial insights. Business Central provides sample financial reports you can use right away as templates [1](#). The **Financial Reports** feature arranges accounts from your chart of accounts in ways that make data easier to present and provides a place for calculations that cannot be made directly in the chart of accounts – for example, you can create subtotals for groups of accounts, calculate profit margins on dimensions such as departments or customer groups, and filter general ledger entries and budget entries by net change or debit amount [1](#). Understanding what is available out of the box ensures you spend more time analysing numbers and less time gathering them.

Exercise: Open your Business Central sandbox and use **Search** (Alt+Q) to enter "**Financial Reports**". On the **Financial Reports** list page, note that by default the page displays reports in a list view; however, you can switch to a tile view using the **View layout options** icon in the upper-right corner [4](#). Review the reports listed. Select one (e.g., **Balance Sheet**) and choose **View**

Financial Report. Observe that data is already structured into meaningful sections based on your general ledger. This confirms that from day one, Business Central gives you a working starting point for financial reporting.

Learn More:

- [Primary capabilities of financial reporting](#)
-

Day 2: Using G/L Account Categories – The Foundation of Built-in Reports

Introduction: Business Central uses **G/L Account Categories** to group your accounts into six major financial statement sections: Assets, Liabilities, Equity, Income, Cost of Goods, and Expense ⁵. G/L account categories simplify your financial report definitions and make them more resilient to changes in the chart of accounts structure ⁵. If you add a new account and assign the proper category, it is automatically included in the relevant reports. This saves time, reduces errors, and keeps your core financial statements aligned with the chart of accounts as it evolves.

Exercise: Navigate to the **G/L Account Categories** page. Review how the six top-level categories and their subcategories are defined ⁵. Verify that each G/L account has an appropriate category and subcategory. Then locate and run the **Generate Financial Reports** action on this page. This action updates financial reports with the **M-** prefix with the mapping provided for your chart of accounts ⁵. After generation, open the **Financial Reports** page and view the Balance Sheet or Income Statement – notice the layout mirrors your category groupings. To control which reports update when you generate, update the fields in the **Reporting** section of the **General Ledger Setup** page ⁵.

Learn More:

- [Organize report data using account categories](#)
-

Day 3: Viewing Financial Reports On-Screen (Drill-Down and Analysis)

Introduction: A key advantage of Business Central's financial reports is interactive data exploration. After you set up definitions, the Financial Reporting feature offers multiple ways to view the reports: on-screen with drill-through to the underlying numbers, as PDF documents designed for sharing and printing, and as Excel files using the template or layout of your choice [4](#). On-screen viewing lets you investigate why a balance changed or what is included in a total, giving you confidence in the figures and the ability to answer management questions immediately.

Exercise: Open the **Financial Reports** page and select a report (e.g., **Income Statement**). Click **View Financial Report**. On the **Options** FastTab, use the **View by** field to change the period (e.g., Month vs. Quarter) and set a **Date Filter** to a specific range [4](#). Toggle the **Show All Lines** switch to include or exclude empty lines as defined in the row definition [4](#). On the **Dimensions** FastTab, filter data according to global dimensions [4](#). If you change a setting, use the **Recalculate** action to refresh the data on the screen [4](#). Finally, click on a figure in the report to drill down – numbers that are not calculated by a formula can take you to the original transactions, including invoices, credit memos, and ledger entries [2](#).

Learn More:

- [View a financial report](#)

Day 4: Printing and Exporting Reports (PDF and Excel)

Introduction: Controllers frequently share financial reports with stakeholders who prefer traditional formats. Business Central offers printing via your device's printing services, options to save reports as PDF files, and export to Excel [4](#). The name of your company always shows in the upper right of the PDF; if you specify a **Display Name** on the **Companies** list page, that name shows instead of the name in the **Name** field [4](#). You can also integrate a financial report with an Excel workbook template, adjust the layout to suit your needs, and then update the Excel template with data from Business

Central ⁴. Mastering these options ensures you can deliver information in the format each audience needs.

Exercise: In the **Financial Reports** list, choose a report (e.g., **Balance Sheet**). Click **Print/PDF**. In the **Printer** field, you will see **(Handled by the browser)**, which indicates no specific printer is configured – the browser handles the printout and displays standard printing steps ⁴. Choose **Preview** to generate a PDF. Observe the layout. Close the preview. Now use the **Send to...** action and choose **Microsoft Excel Document (data only)** – an Excel file downloads with the report data. Open the file and note that you can manipulate or format it further. Through this exercise, you have produced the financial report in both human-readable (PDF) and data-ready (Excel) forms.

Learn More:

- [View a financial report](#)
-

Day 5: Customising Core Financial Statements (Report Selection)

Introduction: Business Central provides built-in Balance Sheet, Income Statement, Cash Flow, and Retained Earnings finance reports. The Financial Reporting feature defines the data and the layouts for these reports, and you can replace the standard layouts that Business Central provides with your own ⁶. For a controller, this means you can make a tailored financial statement and set it as the default used throughout the system. Learning how to change the report selection lets you adapt the system's core reports to your business without affecting underlying data.

Exercise: Navigate to **General Ledger Setup**. On the **Reporting** FastTab, find the fields for the default report names (Balance Sheet, Income Statement, etc.) ⁶. Note which financial report definition is currently used for each. Now, go to **Financial Reports**, select the **Income Statement**, and use the **Copy Financial Report** action. Name the copy "My Income Statement." Return to **General Ledger Setup** and change the **Income Statement** report name field to your newly copied report. Save the change. This tells Business Central to use your report definition when someone runs an income statement. To verify, view the income statement and confirm it pulls from your custom version. After verification, restore the original name if desired.

Learn More:

- [Report selection for finance reports in Business Central](#)
-

Day 6: Scheduling Reports – Automate Your Reporting Routine

Introduction: Rather than manually running reports each period, Business Central allows you to schedule financial reports to run automatically. The schedule can produce the report as an Excel file that shows up in the Report Inbox on your Role Center, as a PDF, or both. If you want to share the report with colleagues, you can set up the schedule to send the report to them by email ⁴. Automating report runs saves time, ensures consistency, and frees you to focus on analysis rather than preparation.

Exercise: In the **Financial Reports** page, choose the **Definitions** action, then choose **Schedules** to open the **Financial Report Schedules** page ⁴. Create a new schedule. In the **Code** field, enter a name (e.g., "WEEKLY") ⁴. In the **Description** field, enter what the report shows (e.g., "Weekly P&L report") ⁴. To export to Excel, select the **Export to Excel** checkbox and choose a template in the **Excel Template Code** field ⁴. To export to PDF, select the **Export to PDF** checkbox ⁴. To send by email, select the **Send Email** checkbox and use the **Recipients** action to specify recipients ⁴. Specify when to run: enter a date formula in the **Recurrence Run Date Formula** field (e.g., **1W** for every one week) and set the **Next Run Date/Time** ⁴. Save the schedule. Business Central will execute the report in the background at the scheduled time.

Learn More:

- [View a financial report](#)
-

Day 7: Global Settings – Configuring Report Preferences

Introduction: Business Central provides default settings on the **Reporting** FastTab of the **General Ledger Setup** page that apply to all financial reports. For example, you can specify the additional currency and whether to adjust exchange rates for taxes, the default category for accounts payable and receivable accounts, the specific report setup (including row and column definitions), the length of the period for which to show amounts, how to

format negative amounts, where to position your company logo when you print reports, and the default status to assign to new reports ¹. These defaults enforce consistency and save effort across all reports.

Exercise: Open **General Ledger Setup** and scroll to the **Reporting** FastTab. Review each available setting. Locate **Neg. Amount Format** and try changing it (e.g., from "-x" to "(x)" for parentheses notation). Click **OK** to save. Run a financial report (e.g., Income Statement) and see how negative amounts appear with the new format. Then revert the setting. Also note fields like **Accounts Payable Category** and **Accounts Receivable Category** – ensure they are set to the appropriate G/L account categories. You can change the default settings on each individual report if needed ¹. This exercise familiarises you with the system-wide levers that control report behaviour.

Learn More:

- [Build financial reports using financial data and account categories](#)
-

Day 8: Managing Report Lifecycle – Drafts, Active, and Retired Reports

Introduction: Business Central allows report authors to specify the status of financial reports, row definitions, and column definitions in the report lifecycle. The system provides statuses such as **Active** (current and ready to use), **Draft** (being developed; should not be used), and **Retired** (no longer current; should not be used) ¹. You can also block a report or definition to prevent people from using it – for example, because it is in a draft or retired status ¹. If these statuses do not fit your needs, you can create your own ¹. Managing the report lifecycle provides version control and clarity, ensuring only approved reports are used for financial analysis.

Exercise: Navigate to **Financial Reports** and locate a report you have been experimenting with. Find the **Status** field and change the status to **Draft**. Next, search for the **Financial Report Statuses** page. Here you see the list of possible statuses, and you can create new custom ones if needed. To block a status, on the **Financial Reports** page, choose the status, and then select the **Blocked** checkbox ¹. Create a new status called "Obsolete" and mark it as Blocked. Assign it to an unused sample report. If you attempt to run a report

with a blocked status, Business Central will prevent usage. Reset statuses as needed. You assign a status to your reports and definitions in the **Status** field on the **Financial Reports** page and the pages for row and column definitions from each report [1](#).

Learn More:

- [Build financial reports using financial data and account categories](#)
-

Day 9: Security and Permissions – Controlling Report Access

Introduction: Financial reports contain sensitive data. Business Central uses permission sets to regulate who can view or edit financial reports. Two built-in permission sets govern access: "**Account Schedules - View**" (allows viewing financial reports) and "**Account Schedules - Edit**" (allows editing financial report definitions, including row and column definitions) [3](#). Note: these permission set names carry the legacy naming convention. Understanding these permissions is crucial for compliance and segregation of duties – for instance, department managers might view reports but not alter report structures. Properly configured permissions protect the integrity of financial reporting.

Exercise: Go to the **Users** or **Permission Sets** page in Business Central and review the permission sets assigned to a test user. Look for **Account Schedules - View** and **Account Schedules - Edit** in the list. If you have a test account, assign only the "View" permission set. Log into Business Central as that user (or simulate by temporarily adjusting your own rights). Try to view a report on the **Financial Reports** page – it should allow viewing. Then attempt to edit a report definition – the system should prevent this. This confirms the two levels of access work as documented. Reassign full permissions when done.

Learn More:

- [Auditing and financial reporting](#)
-

Day 10: Quick Start to Customisation – Copy and Modify a Report

Introduction: A practical way to begin customising is by copying an existing report and making small changes. To copy an existing report, use the **Copy Financial Report** action. When you choose this option, you can rename the copied report. You can also copy and rename individual row definitions and column definitions ⁷. This preserves the original for comparison, reduces effort, and lets you experiment at low risk. For controllers who need a slightly different view of a standard report, copying is the fastest path to customisation.

Exercise: Navigate to **Financial Reports**, select **Balance Sheet**, and choose **Copy Financial Report**. Name the new report "Balance Sheet – Detail" and ensure the copy includes row and column definitions. Open your copied report and choose **Edit Row Definition**. Make a simple change: find the row for Cash and insert a new row below it to separate one cash account from another, adjusting the description and totaling ranges. Save the row definition. View your new report and confirm the change is reflected correctly. You now have a custom version of a core report created with minimal effort.

Learn More:

- [Design your own financial reports](#)
-

Intermediate Lessons (Days 11–20) – Building and Enhancing Financial Reports

Day 11: Row Definitions – Structuring the Report Rows

Introduction: Row definitions in financial reports provide a place for calculations that cannot be made directly in the chart of accounts. For example, you can create subtotals for groups of accounts and then include that total in other totals. You can also calculate intermediate steps that are not shown in the final report ⁸. As a controller designing reports, the row definition determines what appears line by line. Mastering row definitions gives you control over the level of detail, grouping, and narrative in your statements.

Exercise: Go to **Financial Reports**, click **New**, and name a fresh report "**Trial Balance (Custom)**". Choose **Edit Row Definition** and create a new definition (e.g., code "TB-ROWS"). Use **Insert G/L Accounts** to add accounts automatically. Note that the **Row No.** field can hold up to 10 characters and denotes a row identifier such as an account number or text like "Revenue" or "R" ⁸. You use these identifiers for calculated rows in the **Totalling** field. After inserting accounts, add a formula line at the bottom: set **Totalling Type** = Formula and **Totalling** = a formula that sums all rows to verify the total is zero. Close and save. Assign an existing column definition and **View** the report. You have built a basic row definition from scratch.

Learn More:

- [Row definitions in Financial Reporting](#)
-

Day 12: Column Definitions – Defining Timeframes and Data Columns

Introduction: Column definitions complement row definitions by specifying the data and timeframes shown across the report's columns. Use column definitions to specify the columns to include in the report – for example, you can design a report layout to compare net change and balance for the same period this year and last year. You can have up to 15 columns in a column definition ¹. For controllers, well-designed column layouts turn raw data into analysis: current month vs. last year, actual vs. budget, and trend views. Recommended fields for a basic column definition include **Column No.**, **Column Header**, **Column Type**, **Ledger Entry Type**, **Budget Name**, **Formula**, and **Comparison Period Formula** ⁷.

Exercise: Create a new column definition named "**INC-COMP**" (Income Comparison). Design three columns:

1. **Column Header** = "Month", **Column Type** = Net Change, **Ledger Entry Type** = Entries. Leave Comparison Period Formula blank (uses the report's date filter).
2. **Column Header** = "Year to Date", **Column Type** = Net Change, use a **Comparison Period Formula** that captures the fiscal year to the current period.

3. **Column Header** = "Prior Year", **Column Type** = Net Change, **Comparison Period Formula** = **-1Y**.

The often-used Column Type options are **Net Change** (for income statement reports), **Balance at Date** (for balance sheet reports), and **Formula** ⁷. Save the definition. Assign it to a copy of the Income Statement report and view the report for the latest month. You should see three columns of figures enabling period-over-period analysis.

Learn More:

- [Design your own financial reports](#)

Day 13: Walkthrough Example – Trial Balance Report

Introduction: A Trial Balance is a fundamental reconciliation report. The walkthrough examples in Business Central's documentation are based on the demonstration data that Business Central provides for its CRONUS demonstration company ⁹. Creating a trial balance using financial reporting reinforces how to include all accounts and use formulas. If you add a new general ledger account to the chart of accounts, you must update your row definition to include it; otherwise, your trial balance report will not balance to zero ⁹.

Exercise: Follow the documented example:

1. Open a new financial report and name it "Trial Balance".
2. Open the row definition and choose **Insert G/L Accounts**. Filter the **Account Type** column to **Posting** ⁹. To quickly apply the filter, choose any row with "Posting" in the Account Type column, right-click the column header, and choose **Filter to this value** ⁹.
3. Select all posting accounts and choose **OK** to assign them to the row definition ⁹.
4. Add a formula on the last line to sum the results of all lines. Because this is a trial balance report, the expected result is zero ⁹.
5. Assign a column definition (commonly used ones for a trial balance report include **Balance Only**, **M-Balance**, and **Default** ⁹) and view the report. Verify it nets to zero.

Learn More:

- [Create custom financial reports](#)
-

Day 14: Walkthrough Example – Balance Sheet

Introduction: The Balance Sheet groups accounts into categories (Current Assets, Long-Term Assets, Liabilities, Equity) with totals that must balance. Constructing one teaches you to use alphanumeric row codes and formulas. Formulas are expressed as a row number reference, such as "R" or "CA" (current assets), which adds all accounts with that row number ⁹. A well-designed balance sheet should include a check figure confirming that Assets = Liabilities + Equity; if it is not zero, some accounts might not be included, might be included more than once, or a formula might be calculating incorrectly ⁹.

Exercise: Create or copy a Balance Sheet report and edit its row definition. Structure rows using the documented example: assign **Row No.** codes like "CA" for Current Assets (with posting account ranges such as 18000..18999 for Cash, 15000..15999 for Accounts Receivable, etc.) and "LTA" for Long Term Assets (e.g., 10000..12899 for Fixed Assets, 12900..12999 for Accumulated Depreciation) ⁹. Create formula lines: **Total Current Assets** = Formula with Totaling "CA"; **Total Long Term Assets** = Formula with Totaling "LTA"; and **Total Assets** = Formula "F1+F2" ⁹. Mark total lines as **Bold = Yes** for emphasis ⁹. Add similar sections for Liabilities and Equity. At the bottom, insert a hidden check line (Assets minus Liabilities & Equity) with **Show = No**. Use **Balance at Date** as the Row Type for all lines, since balance sheet reports show account balances on a certain date ⁹. View the report and verify the check line equals zero.

Learn More:

- [Create custom financial reports](#)
-

Day 15: Walkthrough Example – Income Statement

Introduction: The Income Statement shows performance over a period and typically requires customisations like subtotals (Gross Profit, Operating Profit,

Net Income) and sign adjustments. Income statements use **Net Change** column types (exploring the activity of each account during a period of time), whereas Balance Sheets use **Balance at Date** (finding account balances on a certain date) [10](#). Learning to construct one teaches you formula chaining and sign control for presentation.

Exercise: Build an Income Statement layout:

1. **Rows:** Create sections for Revenue, Cost of Goods Sold, and Expenses, each with posting account ranges and a shared Row No. code (e.g., "REV", "COGS", "EXP").
2. **Formulas:** Add a Gross Profit line (Formula: REV - COGS), an Operating Profit line, and a Net Income line. Each uses **Totaling Type = Formula** referencing row codes from prior sections.
3. **Sign Control:** Use the **Show Opposite Sign** option to display credit balance accounts (such as revenue) as positive numbers for report readers who are not accountants [7](#). Apply this on the posting account line for the account where the sign needs to be flipped – not on a formula like gross margin, as the calculation will be incorrect if both revenue and cost of goods sold are represented in the formula [7](#).
4. **Columns:** Use a column definition with **Column Type = Net Change** for both current month and year-to-date columns [7](#).
5. **View** the report and verify that subtotals are correct and signs display logically.

Learn More:

- [Create custom financial reports](#)
- [Design your own financial reports](#)

Day 16: Comparative and Trend Reporting (Multiple Periods)

Introduction: Beyond single-period statements, you can apply multiple views to any report you create – for example, formula combinations for standard month-to-date and year-to-date views, trends over the last 12 months, or comparisons of current amounts with the prior month or year [2](#). Two comparison options exist for column definitions: **Comparison Period**

Formula (often used for monthly, quarterly, or annual accounting periods) and **Comparison Date Formula** (typically used for weekly or daily accounting periods, appropriate for operational reporting such as daily sales or weekly invoicing) ⁷. Mastering comparative reporting eliminates the manual work of merging multiple reports in Excel.

Exercise: Expand an existing Income Statement column definition:

1. Add a **Prior Year** column: **Column Type** = Net Change, **Comparison Period Formula** = $-1Y$ ⁷.
2. Add a **% Change** column: **Column Type** = Formula, with a formula referencing the current and prior year columns (e.g., $(A-B)/B$ using the column identifiers).
3. Assign to your Income Statement report and view for a specific month. Inspect a few lines to verify: if Sales this month is 100 and last year was 80, the % Change should reflect 25%.
4. Optionally, create a multi-period trend: use successive Comparison Period Formulas (e.g., $-5M$, $-4M$, ... through current month) to produce a 6-month trend.

Learn More:

- [Primary capabilities of financial reporting](#)
 - [Design your own financial reports](#)
-

Day 17: Budget vs. Actual Reporting

Introduction: Financial reporting can easily compare budget and actual financial results. You can do the comparisons for any date range and view the results at the general ledger and dimension levels ². By integrating budgets into your reports, everyone sees the same up-to-date variance analysis, and you can drill down into variances just as you do into actuals. Budgets can be included on any report by selecting a **Ledger Entry Type** of **Budget Entries** and entering the **Budget Name** for the selected budget on a column definition ⁷.

Exercise: Add budget figures to a financial report:

1. Ensure you have a G/L Budget set up (e.g., "OPERATING 2026") with entries by account and period. If you want to view G/L entries as percentages of budget entries, you must create G/L budgets [1](#).
2. Copy your Income Statement column definition to a new one (e.g., "INC-BUD"). Add a column for **Budget**: set **Column Header** = "Budget", **Column Type** = Net Change, **Ledger Entry Type** = **Budget Entries**, and select the **Budget Name** [7](#).
3. Add a **Variance** formula column (Actual minus Budget) and optionally a % **Variance** column.
4. Assign to the Income Statement report and view for the desired period. Check a specific account against the **G/L Budgets** page to verify the numbers match.

Learn More:

- [Primary capabilities of financial reporting](#)
 - [Design your own financial reports](#)
-

Day 18: Using Dimensions in Financial Reports

Introduction: In financial analysis, a dimension is data you add to an entry as a kind of marker to group entries with similar characteristics – for example, customers, regions, products, and salespeople. The groups let you easily retrieve data about them for analysis [11](#). Each dimension describes the focus of analysis: a two-dimensional analysis might be sales per area, while using more dimensions lets you explore sales per campaign per customer group per area, giving greater insight into how well your business is operating, where it is or is not thriving, and where you should allocate more resources [11](#). As a quick way to analyse transactional data by dimensions, you can filter totals in the chart of accounts and entries in all **Entries** pages by dimensions using the **Set Dimension Filter** action [11](#).

Exercise: Explore two methods:

1. **Report Filter by Dimension:** Open your Income Statement. On the **Dimensions** FastTab when viewing the report, enter a specific dimension

value (e.g., Department = "SALES") and run [4](#). Review results. Change the filter to another department and compare.

2. **Analysis View with Multiple Dimensions:** Go to **Analysis Views** and create a New view (e.g., "P&L by Dept"). Set it to include your Department dimension. Choose the **Update** action to populate data [11](#). Then choose **Analysis by Dimensions**, select your analysis view, specify Department as Columns and G/L Accounts as Rows, and click **Show Matrix** [11](#). This displays a matrix of values giving you a multi-department P&L comparison. If you select the **Update on Posting** checkbox on an analysis view card, the view automatically updates when someone posts an associated transaction [11](#).

Learn More:

- [Analyze data by dimensions](#)

Day 19: Statistical Accounts – Enriching Reports with Non-Financial Data

Introduction: Statistical accounts let you add metrics based on non-transactional data, such as employee headcount, square footage, or the number of customers with overdue accounts [12](#). For example, you can measure revenue or costs based on the number of people in a department. In terms of how they work, statistical accounts are similar to posting accounts – they store transactions posted using statistical account journals so you can use the transactions as data for financial reports [12](#). Key differences: statistical accounts are separate entities, are not included in trial balance reports, and you do not need to balance debit and credit amounts when posting [12](#). This broadens what you can communicate in a financial report beyond the general ledger.

Exercise: Incorporate a statistical account:

1. **Set Up:** Go to **Statistical Accounts** and create a new one (e.g., No. = "EMPCOUNT", Name = "Employee Count").
2. **Post Values:** Click **Statistical Accounts Journal**. Enter a line: set the **Posting date** to the last day of the posting period, **Statistical Account No.**

= "EMPCOUNT", **Description** = "Number of Employees Sep 2026", **Amount** = 50 [12](#). Post the journal.

3. **Verify:** Use the **Statistical Accounts Balance** action to verify that the registered amounts are correct for each period [12](#).
4. **Include in Report:** Open a row definition. Add a row for "Employee Count": set **Totaling Type** = **Statistical Accounts**, **Totaling** = EMPCOUNT [12](#). Give it a Row No. like "SA". Then add a formula row "Revenue per Employee": **Totaling Type** = Formula, **Totaling** = "F1 / SA" (where F1 is your total revenue). In the **Row Type** field, choose whether to view the balance on the posting date or the beginning of the posting period, or to show the change during the period [12](#).
5. **Run the Report:** View it for the relevant period and verify the KPI calculation.

Learn More:

- [Use Statistical Accounts to Analyze Non-Transactional Data](#)

Day 20: Validating Report Accuracy (Reconciliation Techniques)

Introduction: A financial report is only useful if it is accurate. When you create new financial reports, you might find that they do not balance to the general ledger. The most likely reasons include: a new G/L account was added to the chart of accounts but not the financial reporting; general ledger accounts are missing from the Totaling accounts; general ledger accounts are listed multiple times; a formula is missing or points to the wrong row number reference; a formula does not include all the necessary rows; or a formula incorrectly shows a positive value as negative [10](#). Testing against the Trial Balance report is a key technique because it correctly lists all G/L accounts in your chart of accounts and always balances to zero [10](#).

Exercise: Methodically verify one of your custom reports:

1. **Compare to Trial Balance:** Run a **Trial Balance** report for the same period as your Balance Sheet. When running the Trial Balance report, fill out options as follows for a clean reference: in **Show Comparison** choose **Last Year**, turn on **Actual Balances**, in **Round to** choose the lowest value for your currency, turn on **Print to Excel**, on the **Filter** FastTab set

Account Type = Posting, and enter the relevant **Date Filter** [10](#). Export to Excel. Compare line by line with your financial report output; identify any discrepancies.

2. **Alternative Testing Method:** Use the data analysis feature on the **General Ledger Entries** page. This allows you to group and summarize amounts by G/L account or G/L account category, and set filters on relevant data properties [10](#).
3. **Internal Check Lines:** Toggle **Show All Lines** on your report to reveal hidden validation rows. If any check line is non-zero, investigate immediately.

Learn More:

- [Troubleshoot Financial Reporting](#)
- [Financial Reporting FAQ](#)

Expert Lessons (Days 21–30) – Advanced Control, Auditing, and Optimisation

Day 21: Auditing Changes to Financial Reports (Change Log)

Introduction: You can use the **Change Log** feature to capture changes users make to the definitions for financial reports – for example, you can find out what changed, who changed it, and when the change was made [3](#). The relevant tables and their IDs are: Report Definition (Table ID 88), Row Definition (84), Row Definition Lines (85), Column Definition (333), and Column Definition Lines (334) [3](#). Enabling this audit trail is crucial for compliance and internal control: as a controller, you can review modifications to ensure they were authorised and properly executed.

Exercise: Configure the Change Log for financial reports:

1. Go to **Change Log Setup** and enable it if not already active. In the setup details, add entries for the five tables listed above (IDs 88, 84, 85, 333, 334) [3](#). Log all three operations: Insert, Modify, Delete.
2. **Test:** Make a small change to a row definition (e.g., modify a description). Navigate to **Change Log Entries** and filter for today's date and the "Row

Definition" table. You should see an entry capturing the change (user, timestamp, table, field, old value, new value).

3. **Monitor:** Periodically review the Change Log for these tables before critical reporting periods to verify that no one altered a definition since it was last validated.

Learn More:

- [Auditing and financial reporting](#)
-

Day 22: Receiving Notifications of Report Changes

Introduction: To add an extra layer of security around your financial report definitions, you can monitor changes to their fields and get an email when someone changes a value ³. This proactive notification acts as an early warning system so you can review and approve changes promptly, rather than discovering them during a reconciliation. Notifications complement the Change Log by actively pushing updates to you.

Exercise: Configure a notification for changes to financial report definitions:

1. Explore Business Central's built-in notification capabilities. The system can send notifications when setup records change. Configure this for the Financial Report definition tables using the notification mechanism described in the documentation.
2. **Test:** Make a deliberate change to a report definition (e.g., rename a column header). Check for a notification – either an in-app notification (bell icon on Role Center) or email, depending on your configuration.
3. **Review:** Upon receiving notification, inspect the changed report. Open the relevant definition and run the report to verify everything is still correct.

If full automation is complex to set up in a quick exercise, internalise the concept: restricting who can edit (Day 9) combined with active notifications on changes provides a robust control framework for financial report integrity.

Learn More:

- [Auditing and financial reporting](#)
-

Day 23: Reviewing Financial Report Runs (Audit Logs)

Introduction: At some point, you might want to review previous runs for financial reports. From the **Financial Reports** page, you can use the **Audit Logs** action to access information about the selected report, or all audit logs for all reports. The **Financial Report Audit Logs** page shows who ran what, and when, and the format of the report output – for example, whether it was only viewed or also exported to Excel or PDF ³. You can also review report runs that your schedule generated: from the **Financial Report Schedules** page, use the **Logs** action to access a list of earlier runs, and the **Sent Emails** action to review the emails it sent ³. This transparency is essential for controllers managing reporting workflows.

Exercise: Run a financial report (e.g., the Balance Sheet) and export it to PDF. Then:

1. Go back to the **Financial Reports** page and choose the **Audit Logs** action. The **Financial Report Audit Logs** page should show your recent run, including the report name, user, timestamp, and output format (PDF).
2. To narrow the information, apply filters. To dig deeper into the data, turn on analysis mode and create mini-reports ³.
3. If you have a scheduled report from Day 6, open the **Financial Report Schedules** page and use the **Logs** action to see the schedule's run history, including the name of the financial report, the schedule that ran it, and the date and time it ran ³.

Learn More:

- [Auditing and financial reporting](#)
 - [View a financial report](#)
-

Day 24: Validation Figures and Check Totals (Advanced Testing)

Introduction: One way to quickly identify errors in the design of your financial reporting is to add validation figures to your row definitions. You want the figure to calculate to zero, which indicates that the report is correct. When you run financial reporting, a quick glance at the validation figures can confirm whether the report is correct ¹⁰. When you add rows with validation

figures, consider setting the **Show** option to **No** for them. They will not appear on your report PDF output and you can use the **Show All Lines** toggle on the report to show or hide them [10](#). This practice embeds a self-audit in the report.

Exercise: Formalise validation in your reports:

1. Open your custom Balance Sheet's row definition. Create a row at the bottom called "**Check Balance**". Set **Totaling Type** = Formula and enter a formula for Assets minus Liabilities & Equity. Set **Show** = No.
2. Run the report with **Show All Lines** enabled [4](#). Scroll to the bottom and verify the "Check Balance" line displays 0.00. A non-zero value indicates a structural issue.
3. Apply the same technique to your Income Statement: add a formula that sums all revenue and expense rows and subtracts Net Income – the result should be zero.
4. Keep these checks hidden for normal users; they are for your eyes during design/testing. This ensures any structural issues are immediately flagged rather than slipping by unnoticed.

Learn More:

- [Troubleshoot Financial Reporting](#)
 - [Financial Reporting FAQ](#)
-

Day 25: Net Change vs. Balance at Date – Best Practices

Introduction: A typical mistake that financial reporting users make is to incorrectly combine row and column definitions. When column definitions use **Net Change** as the row type, the columns are most appropriately combined with income statement reports. When column definitions use **Balance at Date** as the row type, the columns are most appropriately combined with balance sheet reports [10](#). People use balance sheet reports to find account balances on a certain date (so Balance at Date makes sense), while people use income statement reports to explore activity during a period (so Net Change makes sense) [10](#). When you create column definitions, you might include **BS** or **IS** in the definition description to help report viewers decide which column definitions to use with which reports [10](#).

Exercise: Inspect and correct column definitions:

1. Open the column definition used for your Balance Sheet. Verify every column uses **Balance at Date**. If you find Net Change, change it.
2. Open the Income Statement column definition. Verify every column uses **Net Change** (or Net Change with a period formula for YTD). If you find Balance at Date, replace it with Net Change and the appropriate Comparison Period Formula.
3. Run both reports and confirm: the Balance Sheet shows ending balances (not period movements), and the Income Statement shows period activity (not cumulative balances).
4. As a naming convention, consider adding "BS" or "IS" to your column definition descriptions to communicate their intended use [10](#). While experienced accountants sometimes apply either view for trend analysis [10](#), establishing the convention for the general audience ensures consistent, correct usage.

Learn More:

- [Troubleshoot Financial Reporting](#)
 - [Financial Reporting FAQ](#)
-

Day 26: KPI Web Service – Publishing Report Data for Power BI

Introduction: On the **Financial Report KPI Web Service Setup** page, you set up how to show the financial report key performance indicator (KPI) data and which specific financial reports to base the KPIs on. When you choose **Publish Web Service**, the specified financial report KPI data is added to the list of published web services on the **Web Services** page [13](#). When you use this web service, closing dates are not included in your data set; you can use filters in Power BI to analyse various time periods [13](#). This enables you to bridge Business Central with external business intelligence tools, ensuring consistency between your BC reports and your dashboards.

Exercise: Publish a financial report as a KPI web service:

1. Search for "**Financial Report KPI Web Service Setup**" [13](#).

2. On the **General** FastTab, fill in the fields [13](#). On the **Row Definitions** FastTab, select the financial report and specify which rows to publish (e.g., Total Revenue and Net Income) [13](#). Repeat for all financial reports you want to include [13](#).
3. To view or edit the selected financial report, on the **Row definitions** FastTab, choose the **Edit Row Definition** action [13](#).
4. To view the KPI data you have set up, choose the **Financial Report KPI Web Service** action [13](#).
5. Click **Publish Web Service** [13](#). You can now create financial reports in Power BI based on the web service or services that you created [13](#). You can also publish the KPI web service by pointing to the setup page object from the **Web Services** page [13](#).
6. In Power BI Desktop, choose **Get Data > OData Feed** and paste the OData URL from the **Web Services** page. Connect and build visuals. Any time you refresh in Power BI, it fetches the latest financial figures from Business Central.

Learn More:

- [Set Up and Publish KPI Web Services Based on Financial Reports](#)
-

Day 27: Cash Flow Forecast via Financial Reports

Introduction: This walkthrough describes how you can use the financial reports feature to make cash flow forecasts. Financial reports perform calculations that cannot be done directly in the chart of cash flow accounts. In the financial reports, you can set up subtotals for cash flow receipts and disbursements, which can then be included in new totals to make cash flow forecasts [14](#). The walkthrough demonstrates tasks performed by the **Controller** role [14](#) and covers setting up a new financial report name, setting up row definition lines, setting up a new column definition, assigning a column definition, and viewing and printing the cash flow forecast [14](#).

Exercise: Summarised from the official walkthrough:

1. **New Financial Report:** Create a report called "**Forecast**" with Description = "Cash Flow Forecast" [14](#).

2. **Row Definition Lines:** Choose **Edit Row Definition** and use the **Insert CF Accounts** function to mark cash flow accounts from the chart and copy them to row definition lines [14](#). For example, insert CF Account 10 (Receivables), 20 (Open sales orders), 30 (Rentals), 40 (Financial assets), and so on [14](#). Group lines with shared Row No. codes (e.g., "R10" for cash receipts) to enable subtotals and formulas.
3. **Column Definition:** Set up a column definition showing the forecast periods. Ensure the columns reference **Cash Flow Entry Accounts** and use appropriate **Row Type** (e.g., Net Change) and **Amount Type** (e.g., Net Amount) [14](#).
4. **View:** Assign the column definition and view the report. Verify that cash inflows and outflows are populated from the cash flow forecast data and that subtotals are correct.

Prerequisites: Business Central and a cash flow worksheet with registered lines [14](#).

Learn More:

- [Make cash flow forecasts using financial reports](#)

Day 28: Exporting and Importing Report Definitions (Reuse Across Companies)

Introduction: Financial report, row, and column definitions are stored as data in the Business Central database. To make sure your definitions are not overwritten or changed during upgrade, new definitions are only available in new Business Central tenants [15](#). To make new definitions available in existing companies, you create a new tenant, export the definitions as configuration packages, sign in to your target company, and import the configuration packages with the new definitions [15](#). This portability is valuable for multi-entity organisations or when migrating from test to production environments.

Exercise: Export and import a financial report definition:

1. **Export:** Create a Configuration Package in Business Central. Add tables 88, 84, 85, 333, and 334 (the same table IDs used for the Change Log in Day

- 21) [3](#). Apply filters to include only the specific report definitions you want to transfer. Export the package to a file.
2. **Import:** In the target company, load and import the configuration package file. Validate and apply the package. The report, row, and column definitions should be recreated in the new company.
3. **Verify:** Open the **Financial Reports** page in the target company, find the imported report, and run it. Make any minor adjustments needed if account numbering or dimension codes differ.

This technique also applies when Microsoft ships new sample reports in a new version – you can export them from a fresh tenant and import into your existing environment.

Learn More:

- [Financial Reporting FAQ](#)
-

Day 29: Performance Optimisation for Large Reports

Introduction: Each cell in a financial report requires the Business Central server to do a calculation, most likely reading a lot of data from the general ledger entries. This means that the time needed to run a report is proportional to the number of cells. For example, a report using a row definition with 50 lines and a column definition with 13 lines will need to do $50 \times 13 = 650$ calculations. But if the report uses a row definition with 500 lines, the number of calculations needed will be 6,500, and therefore the time to run the report will be 10 times longer [10](#). The Business Central client only calculates cells that are visible on the page, so you might not experience the performance impact of large row definitions until you run the report to Excel or PDF, where all cells need to be calculated [10](#).

Exercise: Optimise a large report:

1. **Assess Complexity:** Open the row definition of your largest report and count the lines. Multiply by the number of columns. If the product exceeds several thousand, consider optimisation.

2. **Simplify:** Create a summary version of the report (group accounts by category) with far fewer rows for daily use. Reserve the full detail version for reconciliation only.
3. **Schedule Heavy Reports:** For necessary large reports, use **Schedules** (from Day 6) to run them in the background. If you use large row definitions, you might want to schedule reports and get the output in your Business Central report inbox or in an email, so you can keep working on other tasks without waiting for the report to complete [10](#).
4. **Test:** Schedule the large report, then check the Report Inbox or your email for the output. Confirm the data is correct and the process did not block your session.

Learn More:

- [Troubleshoot Financial Reporting](#)
-

Day 30: Final Challenge – Build a Custom Executive Summary Report

Introduction: This capstone exercise brings together the skills acquired over 30 days into a single deliverable: a custom "Executive Summary" financial report. Such a report might present key financial metrics on one page – revenue, gross margin, operating expenses, net income, selected balance sheet figures, and efficiency ratios – for the month and year-to-date, compared to budget and prior year. This is precisely the type of concise, high-impact report a controller prepares monthly for executives. It exercises report design, formula calculations, statistical account integration, budget columns, comparative formulas, formatting, and validation – a true culmination of your learning.

Exercise: Design an "Executive Summary Financial Report":

1. **Plan the Content:** Revenue, COGS, Gross Profit, Operating Expenses, Net Income (from Income Statement data); Cash, A/R, A/P (from Balance Sheet data); Revenue per Employee (from statistical account). Include comparative columns for Year-to-date vs. Budget and Year-to-date vs. Last Year.

2. **Row Definition:** Create sections separated by headers for "Income Statement", "Balance Sheet KPIs", and "Efficiency Metrics". Use posting account rows for direct account data, formula rows for subtotals (Gross Profit = Revenue – COGS) and ratios (GP% = Gross Profit / Revenue), and a statistical account row for Employee Count. Format headers with **Bold** and total lines with **Underline** ⁸. Remember that some formatting options (Italic, Underline, Double Underline, New Page) do not carry over to reports when you use the Export to Excel action; if you often export to Excel, you might just use Excel's own formatting tools ⁸.
3. **Column Definition:** Design 4 columns: Current Month Actual (Net Change), Current Month Budget (Net Change, Budget Entries), YTD Actual (Net Change with fiscal year formula), and YTD Last Year (Net Change, -1Y). For Balance Sheet KPI rows, use **Balance at Date** row type to show ending balances.
4. **Validate:** Add a hidden check line verifying that Net Income matches the change in Retained Earnings or key formula outputs. Run the report for the latest period with budget loaded and prior-year actuals present. Check that all calculations are correct and all lines populate.
5. **Distribute:** Once refined, consider scheduling this report (Day 6) to email it after monthly close, or publishing its key figures as a KPI web service (Day 26) for a Power BI dashboard.

Learn More:

- [Build financial reports using financial data and account categories](#)
- [Row definitions in Financial Reporting](#)
- [Design your own financial reports](#)

References

1. Primary capabilities of financial reporting

Describes the capabilities most widely used for the financial reporting feature in Business Central, including out-of-the-box financial reporting, custom reports, comparative views, direct tie to the general ledger, dimensions, budget integration, drill-down ability, Export to Excel, and the no-code design philosophy ².

[Read on Microsoft Learn](#)

2. Build financial reports using financial data and account categories (Prepare financial reporting)

The central reference for the Financial Reports feature, covering prerequisites (chart of accounts structure, dimensions, G/L budgets), built-in report selection, default settings on the General Ledger Setup page, the anatomy of financial reports (Name, Description, Row definition, Column definition, Internal description), report lifecycle management (statuses, blocking), and how to create and compare reports ¹.

[Read on Microsoft Learn](#)

3. Report selection for finance reports in Business Central

Explains how Business Central's built-in Balance Sheet, Income Statement, Cash Flow, and Retained Earnings reports use financial report definitions, and how to change the default report definitions on the General Ledger Setup page's Reporting section ⁶. Emphasises the role of G/L account categories in simplifying report definitions.

[Read on Microsoft Learn](#)

4. View a financial report

Guides users on viewing reports on-screen with drill-through, printing and saving as PDF, exporting to Excel with templates, scheduling reports for automated delivery (including email and Report Inbox), and reviewing report runs via audit logs ⁴. Describes Options and Dimensions FastTabs for filtering data.

[Read on Microsoft Learn](#)

5. Organize report data using account categories

Explains how G/L Account Categories (six categories: Assets, Liabilities, Equity, Income, Cost of Goods, Expense) and subcategories map general ledger accounts for automatic financial report generation ⁵. Covers the **Generate Financial Reports** action (which updates M-prefixed reports) and the Change Log for auditing account category changes (Table ID 570) ⁵.

[Read on Microsoft Learn](#)

6. Design your own financial reports

A practical guide to creating new financial reports from scratch, including using default settings, copying existing reports, building your own row and column definitions, using the Show Opposite Sign option, and working with Comparison Period Formula vs. Comparison Date Formula in column

definitions ⁷. Includes recommended field settings for beginners.

[Read on Microsoft Learn](#)

7. Row definitions in Financial Reporting

Comprehensive reference for row definitions: creating new definitions, editing content (Insert G/L Accounts, Insert CF Accounts, Insert Cost Types), working with row formulas (supporting +, -, *, / and the A%B percentage syntax), built-in row definitions, and formatting options (Bold, Italic, Underline, Double Underline, New Page, Show Opposite Sign) ⁸. Notes that the Row No. field can hold up to 10 characters ⁸.

[Read on Microsoft Learn](#)

8. Create custom financial reports (Walkthrough)

Provides three worked examples based on the CRONUS demonstration company ⁹: Example 1 creates a Trial Balance (inserting all posting accounts and verifying the net is zero) ⁹, Example 2 creates a Balance Sheet (grouping accounts with alphanumeric row codes like "CA" and "LTA", using formula subtotals, and adding a check figure) ⁹, and Example 3 creates an Income Statement with revenue and expense sections.

[Read on Microsoft Learn](#)

9. Make cash flow forecasts using financial reports (Walkthrough)

Describes how to use financial reports to make cash flow forecasts by setting up a cash flow financial report name, defining row definition lines using the Insert CF Accounts function, configuring a column definition for forecast periods, and viewing the completed forecast ¹⁴. The walkthrough is performed by the Controller role at CRONUS and requires Business Central and a cash flow worksheet with registered lines ¹⁴.

[Read on Microsoft Learn](#)

10. Set Up and Publish KPI Web Services Based on Financial Reports

Explains how to expose financial report KPI data as OData web services for use in Power BI or Excel. Covers the **Financial Report KPI Web Service Setup** page, selecting row definitions and financial reports to publish, and using the **Publish Web Service** action to add the data to the Web Services page ¹³. Notes that closing dates are not included in the data set ¹³.

[Read on Microsoft Learn](#)

11. Troubleshoot Financial Reporting

Provides resolutions to common problems: balancing reports to the general ledger (listing causes like missing accounts, duplicate accounts, wrong formulas) [10](#), testing against Trial Balance reports as a reference [10](#), testing against data analysis on G/L entries [10](#), adding validation figures with Show = No [10](#), understanding when to use net change vs. balance at date [10](#), and performance considerations (cells = rows × columns, client calculates only visible cells, schedule heavy reports for background processing) [10](#).

[Read on Microsoft Learn](#)

12. Use Statistical Accounts to Analyze Non-Transactional Data

Introduces statistical accounts for adding non-transactional metrics (employee headcount, square footage, overdue customer count) to financial reports [12](#). Covers setting up statistical accounts, posting amounts via Statistical Accounts Journal, verifying balances, and including the statistical account in a financial report row definition using Totaling Type = Statistical Accounts [12](#).

[Read on Microsoft Learn](#)

13. Analyze data by dimensions

Describes how dimensions (data markers for customers, regions, products, salespeople) enable multi-dimensional financial analysis [11](#). Covers setting up Analysis Views, using the Analysis by Dimensions matrix (with Show as Lines / Show as Columns options), updating views (including the Update on Posting option), and the Set Dimension Filter quick-analysis action [11](#).

[Read on Microsoft Learn](#)

14. Auditing and financial reporting

Explains how to monitor changes to financial report definitions and control access. Covers the Change Log setup (with table IDs 88, 84, 85, 333, 334), email notifications when definitions change, the Data Analysis feature for investigating who changed what and when, telemetry for changes and usage, permission sets for viewing and editing, and the Financial Report Audit Logs page for reviewing report runs [3](#).

[Read on Microsoft Learn](#)

15. Financial Reporting FAQ

Answers frequently asked questions: how to access new definitions after an upgrade (export/import via configuration packages) [15](#), why reports do not

balance with the general ledger [15](#), how to test reports using check figures [15](#), when to use net change vs. balance at date [15](#), which users can run or modify reports [15](#), and how to set up auditing and notifications for changes [15](#).

[Read on Microsoft Learn](#)